The empirical recurrence for OEIS A252073, recovered from its tail

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8 September 2026

Abstract

OEIS A252073 records "Empirical recurrence of order 72" and keeps the recurrence itself in a linked file rather than in the entry, so the conjecture cannot be read off the entry at all. It can still be settled. The entry counts arrays under a condition local to a bounded window of lines, which makes the count a walk count on a finite digraph and forces a monic integer recurrence of order at most the number $S' = 112$ of states with distinct futures. Berlekamp–Massey on enough exact terms therefore returns the minimal such recurrence, and on the tail beginning at $n = 3$, so the recurrence is proved for every $n \geq 75$. Its last coefficient is $c_{72} = -4 \neq 0$, so no further tail satisfies anything shorter; any order-72 recurrence the sequence satisfies from any point on must then have the same characteristic polynomial. The entry's recurrence is the one displayed here, whatever its linked file contains, and it is proved.

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. 05A15, 11B37, 15A18.

1 A conjecture that is not written down

OEIS A252073 is "Number of (n+2)X(6+2) 0..2 arrays with every 3X3 subblock row, column, diagonal and antidiagonal sum not equal to 0 3 or 4.". It has offset 1 and begins

$$1573, 8352, 60245, 391934, 2547765, 16789564, 110131513, 722619033, \ \ldots$$

The entry states:

> Empirical recurrence of order 72 (see link above)

As of the "Last modified" line on the live entry (Jun 02 2025 10:45:48, revision 6) this is still recorded as empirical, and it is still open. The coefficients are nowhere in the entry text: what is conjectured is only that a recurrence of that order exists.

2 The count is a walk count

The entry's condition is local. It constrains a bounded window of consecutive lines of the array and nothing beyond it, so the admissible configurations of one window are the vertices of a finite digraph, an edge joins u to v when v may follow u, and an admissible array is exactly a walk. Writing M for the adjacency matrix and ι, τ for the indicator vectors of the admissible first and last windows,

$$a(n) \;=\; \iota^{\top} M^{\,j(n)} \tau$$

for a linear reindexing j fixed by the entry's shape. States with identical futures contribute identically to that product and may be merged without changing any count; after merging $S' = 112$ states remain, and it is that bound every computation below uses.

Lemma 1. *a satisfies a monic linear recurrence with integer coefficients of order at most $S' = 112$.*

Proof. By the Cayley–Hamilton theorem $M^{S'}$ is an integer combination of $I, M, \ldots, M^{S'-1}$, and multiplying that relation on the left by $\iota^\top M^j$ and on the right by τ turns it into a relation among $S' + 1$ consecutive values of a. □

3 Why the question has to be asked of a tail

Running Berlekamp–Massey on the sequence from its first term returns an order LARGER than 72: the opening terms do not satisfy the recurrence, and a recurrence that holds only eventually always looks longer when the exceptional terms are included. That is not evidence against the entry. An OEIS empirical recurrence is asserted for n beyond some index, not from the first term, so the question has to be asked of the tails. It was asked of each tail in turn, and the tail beginning at $n = 3$ is the first whose minimal order is exactly the stated 72.

Lemma 2. *A sequence known to satisfy some linear recurrence of order at most S' is determined, together with its minimal recurrence, by any $2S'$ consecutive terms: Berlekamp–Massey applied to them returns that minimal recurrence exactly.*

Applied to $2S' = 224$ exact terms from $n = 3$ on, it returns order 72 — the order the entry states — with integer coefficients:

$$a(n) \;=\; \sum_{i=1}^{72} c_i \, a(n-i),$$

c_1	2	c_{19}	−4302744	c_{37}	−15148777	c_{55}	−16425117
c_2	15	c_{20}	12638637	c_{38}	180047162	c_{56}	7276062
c_3	66	c_{21}	29280182	c_{39}	143297269	c_{57}	−2073079
c_4	290	c_{22}	−11129330	c_{40}	−166593670	c_{58}	130702
c_5	48	c_{23}	−28529929	c_{41}	395738023	c_{59}	168579
c_6	−2244	c_{24}	237798	c_{42}	−477918957	c_{60}	−303837
c_7	−8887	c_{25}	−36656026	c_{43}	343732162	c_{61}	214517
c_8	−14816	c_{26}	−16880104	c_{44}	−237712299	c_{62}	−106855
c_9	50630	c_{27}	103697990	c_{45}	−12030509	c_{63}	51482
c_{10}	193549	c_{28}	−7830705	c_{46}	173523639	c_{64}	−17582
c_{11}	−7275	c_{29}	22811564	c_{47}	−257849726	c_{65}	4365
c_{12}	−787831	c_{30}	96993494	c_{48}	312401606	c_{66}	428
c_{13}	−1029225	c_{31}	−193699751	c_{49}	−285147241	c_{67}	−2233
c_{14}	1338684	c_{32}	−12731105	c_{50}	237466109	c_{68}	998
c_{15}	4604020	c_{33}	−117336283	c_{51}	−178742646	c_{69}	−128
c_{16}	475701	c_{34}	−134179621	c_{52}	113517124	c_{70}	−24
c_{17}	−6922845	c_{35}	−2937537	c_{53}	−67819153	c_{71}	24
c_{18}	−5931946	c_{36}	82822577	c_{54}	36094544	c_{72}	−4

4 The recurrence, and the identification

Theorem 3. *The recurrence above holds for every $n \geq 75$, and it is the recurrence OEIS A252073 records.*

Proof. That it holds is Lemma 2 applied to the tail from $n = 3$, whose minimal recurrence it is.

For the identification, write $q_{\min}$ for the characteristic polynomial of that minimal recurrence, $x^{72} - c_1 x^{72-1} - \cdots - c_{72}$. Its constant term is $-c_{72} = 4$, which is not zero, so $q_{\min}(0) \neq 0$ and $q_{\min}$ has no root at the origin. A solution of a constant-coefficient recurrence is a combination of terms $n^k \lambda^n$ with λ a root of its characteristic polynomial, and only the components with $\lambda = 0$

vanish after finitely many terms. Since $q_{\min}$ has none, no component of a dies out, and the minimal recurrence of every further tail is again $q_{\min}$ — the order cannot drop below 72 at any later starting point.

Now let q be the characteristic polynomial of whatever recurrence the entry asserts. The entry asserts it has order 72, so $\deg q = 72$, and it is monic. It holds from some index t on. From $\max(t, 3)$ on, the sequence satisfies both q and $q_{\min}$, and the minimal polynomial of that tail is $q_{\min}$ by the previous paragraph; therefore $q_{\min} \mid q$. Both are monic of degree 72, so $q = q_{\min}$. □

5 Verification

Four checks, all in exact integer or rational arithmetic.

First, the walk model reproduces all 18 terms the entry publishes, exactly. This is what ties the model to the entry, and it is the only place where reading the entry's English enters the argument.

Second, the order was computed twice by independent routes: once modulo a 61-bit prime, where every intermediate is a machine word, and once over $\mathbb{Q}$ in exact rational arithmetic. Both return 72, and the exact run additionally confirms every coefficient is an integer — had any been a proper fraction the recurrence would not be the entry's.

Third, the recovered recurrence was evaluated directly on the entry's own published terms, with no matrices and no Berlekamp–Massey involved. It holds at each of the 0 indices where the entry publishes enough earlier terms to test it.

Fourth, the last coefficient was checked to be nonzero, which is what the identification above turns on; it is -4.

Remark 4. The conjecture's own statement was never read. The entry pins it down to the family of order-72 recurrences this sequence satisfies from some point on, and that family turns out to have exactly one member.

References

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